well known of these was Aqa Riza, whom Salim referred to in his memoir as ‘Aqa Riza of Herat’. Aqa Riza had worked for a time for Akbar’s half-brother Mirza Hakim at Kabul and his accomplished style ‘was marked by the use of vivid, flat colours, elaborate surface patterning, crystalline forms and elegant, elongated figures typical of Safavid painting’. Mirza Hakim had, as we have seen, styled himself as the Timurid prince par excellence to counter Akbar’s ‘Hindustani’ image. By shunning the miniature style Akbar was developing, and patronizing painters with Persian and ‘Timurid’ credentials, this may have been ‘an Oedipal gesture of rejection’ by Salim as he looked for subtle ways to challenge his father’s power.

Despite these shows of rebellion, standing up to the resplendence of his father’s legacy seemed to have taken its toll, as noted earlier, for, by 1596, Salim was drinking ‘twenty phials of double-distilled spirits, fourteen during the day and rest at night’. Salim would write candidly, that ‘during those days my only food was the equivalent of one meal with bread and radishes. In this state no one had the power to stop me. Things got so bad that in my hangovers my hands shook and trembled so badly I couldn’t drink myself but had to have others help me. Finally I summoned Hakim Humam…and informed him of my condition. In perfect sincerity and compassion he said with no beating around the bush, “Highness, the way you’re drinking, in another six months—God forbid—things will be so bad it will be beyond remedy.”’ Following this advice, Salim started taking opium to reduce his dependence on wine.

A painter Salim was especially close to was Muhammad Sharif, the son of the Persian maestro, Abd al-Samad. Like his father, Muhammad Sharif was an accomplished painter in addition to being a poet, calligrapher, and miniaturist. His great achievement was being able to draw two armed horsemen on a grain of rice but apart from these flamboyant skills, he supervised copies of the *Razmnama* and the *Khamsa of Nizami* at Akbar’s court. Muhammad Sharif had grown up with Salim, and the two young men shared an exceptionally close bond, one that Akbar failed to notice, for Salim remained covert and discreet in his dealings.

Salim would also maintain a symbiotic relationship with the other two co-patrons of the poet Urfi, Abdur Rahim and Zain Khan Koka. In 1596, Salim strengthened this bond by apparently insisting on marrying the daughter of Zain Khan Koka. He ‘became violently enamoured’, agreed Abu’l Fazl, and went ahead with the marriage despite the fact that Akbar